

ELLEN DOUGLAS WILLIAMSON

1905–1984

Iowa native Ellen Williamson wrote the well-received *Wall Street Made Easy—An Unconventional Guide to Profitable Investing*. While she admitted she wasn't a famous tycoon, nor a Harvard professor, nor a former president of the New York Stock Exchange (all apparently prerequisites for penning investment books), she felt she had two traits going for her: (1) she had been playing the market since 1927 and was still solvent; and (2) she hated the dry and jargon-filled books currently on the market. In fact, her reason for writing the book, she said, was to give the reader a practical guide that wasn't compromised by cryptic language and an overabundance of charts and graphs.

Williamson, who graduated from Vassar College in 1927, was certainly brash and honest; consider her thoughts on mutual funds: "Mutual funds are perfect for the people who don't give a fig for high finance, or who can't make decisions, or who are just plain lazy." Her 1965 investment book was based on experience; she was a trainee at the Guaranty Trust Company's bond school and later was a director of Hazeltine & Perkins, a pharmaceutical company, for 26 years. One of her strategies in picking stocks was to bounce ideas off four or five more experienced friends.

But ultimately, Williamson believed you had to have faith in yourself, and she snubbed Wall Street firms, especially when leadership was needed. Whether banking or investment institutions, she did not believe they acted as "steadying forces" in the face of crises or panics. "And why is this? Because these institutions are managed by individuals who worry like regular folks. . . ." She also believed there was only so much an individual could do to control their own future. Regardless of how much attention you pay to various market indexes, Williamson warned, "In conclusion, don't forget that nothing but nothing can foretell what's going to happen in the future; also it's hard to find a substitute for good judgment . . ." Like other successful investors, she understood that temperament was critical, and in *Do-It-Yourself Investing* she explains why you can't be a muffin, a snowflake, or an impatient Griseldo.